14 Corps located at Leh had two Divisions (3 Div and 8 Div), out of which only one Division i.e., 3 Mtn Div was looking after the entire front of 800-plus km from the Karakorum Pass to Mt Gya, which as events showed was totally inadequate. It is not as if Northern Command was not seized of this problem and over the years, many Army Commanders had made a bid for an additional Division for this area. Unfortunately, it never saw the light of day, probably due to the preoccupation with CI/CT operations and a 'hot' LC. There was also a perception (equally shared by me), that Northern Command was like a bottomless well, where any number of forces could be sent, never to revert. In fact, Northern Command, which used to look after only one state (now divided into the two UTs of J & K and Ladakh), has 12 x Divisions of which only one (3 Inf Div) is in Ladakh. In the Central Sector, from Mt Gya to the Nepal border, were just three independent Brigades, one in Himachal Pradesh and two in Uttarakhand, reporting directly to the Command HQ in Chandimandir and Lucknow, respectively. Eastern Command was comparatively better off, with three Divisions in each of its Corps. This also implied that the Northern Front was being looked after by four different Command HQs—Northern, Western, Central and Eastern—not an ideal situation at all.

While deliberations were ongoing to redress this imbalance, the crisis in Eastern Ladakh occurred and served as a catalyst for the rebalancing plans. A large number of troops had already been inducted into Eastern Ladakh to deal with the situation; there was now a requirement of providing one more HQ for effective Command and Control, for which CIF(U) along with two of its Sectors (Brigades) was chosen since that area (Udhampur) was relatively dormant. In the Central Sector, each of the Independent Brigades had no reserves, operating as they were in isolated sub-sectors. 14 Div

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